

What's in a Name? Perceived Ethnic Discrimination in Tokyo's Rental Housing Market*

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Abstract

This paper studies perceived ethnic discrimination in Tokyo's rental housing market within Japan's contemporary legal and institutional framework. Using a survey-based experiment, native Japanese and foreign-born respondents evaluate the likelihood that otherwise identical rental applicants with ethnically identifiable names receive a viewing invitation for the same property. We document five main findings. First, both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents expect non-Japanese applicants to face significantly lower viewing probabilities than otherwise identical Japanese applicants. Second, native Japanese respondents perceive substantially larger penalties than foreign-born respondents. Third, perceived disadvantage varies across applicant groups and is smallest for Western-Japanese applicants, suggesting that perceived access is shaped not only by foreignness itself but also by signals of cultural proximity and partial insider status. Fourth, among foreign-born respondents, prior experiences of everyday discrimination are associated with more pessimistic expectations regarding rental access. Fifth, respondents evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group, consistent with the personal-group discrimination discrepancy (PGDD), suggesting that perceptions of disadvantage are shaped differently at the personal and collective levels. The paper contributes to the literature by shifting attention from realised discrimination to subjective expectations of discrimination in housing markets.

Keywords: Perceived discrimination; Ethnic discrimination; Rental housing; Housing access; Immigration; Anti-discrimination law; Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy; Japan

JEL codes: J15, R31, R21, C90, D91, K38

*We thank Takeru Sugawara, Chihiro Shimizu, Yoshinori Sumiya and Atsushi Yamagishi for insights from which the project greatly benefitted as well as valuable information and guidance. Further, we thank participants in the *ENHR Working Group Workshop (European Network for Housing Research) - Families, Housing, and the Asset Society* at the *University of Cambridge* for their comments. The project benefits from generous funding from the *Cambridge University Land Society* and the *Department of Land Economy*. Contact: JA - ja779@cantab.ac.uk, SW - sw2123@cam.ac.uk, KN - kn364@cam.ac.uk, HB - hxb20@cam.ac.uk. Corresponding author: HB - hxb20@cam.ac.uk.

1 Introduction

Access to housing is central to social and economic integration, yet discrimination in rental markets remains widespread, particularly for ethnic minorities and immigrants. Housing discrimination matters not only because it restricts access to accommodation, but also because it may shape neighbourhood choice, labour-market integration, and broader patterns of social inclusion. Focusing on the rental market is especially salient in the Tokyo context, where renting constitutes the dominant tenure form: the homeownership rate is approximately 44.6% in Tokyo, compared to around 61% nationwide, implying that a majority of households in the capital rely on rental housing.¹ Japan provides a particularly important setting in which to study these dynamics. Following the 2018 immigration reform, the country has experienced growing reliance on foreign labour and a rising foreign-born population (Chiavacci, 2025), while comprehensive anti-discrimination protections in the private rental market remain limited.

More broadly, Japan's immigration and social institutions continue to reflect persistent ethnic hierarchies (Shipper, 2016). Scholarship on East Asian migration regimes further suggests that foreign workers are often incorporated as economically necessary yet socially temporary populations (Bell and Piper, 2005; Stilz, 2010). In institutional contexts where pathways to equal social membership remain limited, exclusionary treatment may become more socially normalised, shaping not only realised housing access but also broader expectations regarding who is perceived as legitimately belonging within key social institutions such as housing.

Existing evidence suggests that exclusionary behaviour in Japan's housing market remains persistent. Correspondence studies document differential treatment by landlords and real-estate agents (Sugasawa and Harano, 2023), while repeated nationwide surveys commissioned by the Japanese Ministry of Justice report that foreign residents frequently experience difficulties securing housing. Exclusionary screening practices also remain visible in publicly accessible rental advertisements, where expressions such as 'no foreigners,' 'foreigners negotiable,' and 'foreigners allowed' continue to appear on major housing platforms.²

The existing research on Japanese housing discrimination aligns with most existing research on housing discrimination in other jurisdictions, which focuses on discriminatory behaviour, measuring landlords' behaviour directly through correspondence experiments. This approach builds on a broader audit- and field-experimental literature measuring discrimination in housing and related markets, including studies on trends in discrimination and racial disparities in urban housing outcomes (Ross, 2017; Gould Ellen and Ross, 2018).

Such behavioural studies that identify whether differential treatment occurs, however, do not reveal the resulting social status that different groups hold in the housing market. This distinction is important because discriminatory conduct and the social status resulting from that conduct are not identical phenomena. The shared beliefs regarding the latter constitute what may be termed the perceived probabilistic status of access: socially and normatively shared expectations regarding the likelihood that members of particular groups will successfully obtain

¹See <https://stats-japan.com/t/kiji/11963>, last accessed in May 2026.

²See Ministry of Justice Japan, 2024 Report on the Basic Survey Foreign Residents, available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001436052.pdf> (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001450859.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001436044.pdf> ; 2022 Report on the Basic Survey of Foreign Residents, available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001402047.pdf> (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415876.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415884.pdf> ; 2021 Report on the Basic Survey of Foreign Residents, available at <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001378514.pdf>: (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415911.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415921.pdf>).

housing. Such perceptions are important independently of the occurrence of individual acts of differential treatment, for at least three reasons.

First, subjective expectations of discrimination may reveal broader beliefs regarding the social appropriateness of exclusionary behaviour. Experimental evidence suggests that discriminatory behaviour is sensitive not only to private preferences but also to perceived social norms regarding the acceptability of discrimination (Barr et al., 2018). In institutional environments where anti-discrimination norms are comparatively weak or ambiguously enforced, market participants may therefore anticipate greater discriminatory treatment even absent direct personal experience. Recent evidence further shows that laws may influence social norms and normative beliefs even beyond direct legal enforcement (Lane et al., 2023).

Second, perceptions are economically consequential even when they diverge from the actual occurrence of discriminatory behaviour. Anticipated discrimination may influence search intensity, application strategies, neighbourhood choice, and willingness to participate in particular housing markets. Perceived barriers to housing access may therefore contribute to residential sorting and unequal integration outcomes independently of realised landlord behaviour. Relatedly, Boeri et al. (2015) show that housing-market discrimination may affect immigrant integration beyond housing itself by shaping residential concentration and employment outcomes.

Third, and most fundamentally, perceived access to housing markets also carries symbolic consequences beyond the denial of particular housing opportunities. As Brest (1976) argues in the context of segregation, discrimination operates partly through the stigmatisation of certain groups as socially inferior, while Hellman (2011) emphasises the demeaning and status-expressive dimensions of unequal treatment. Differential treatment may therefore shape beliefs about the social worth and societal acceptance of particular groups. In this sense, housing-market discrimination carries both allocative and symbolic consequences (Horgan, 2020; Wacquant, 2007; Hastings, 2004).

Because the symbolic dimensions of discrimination emerge through socially recognised relations of status and belonging (Anderson, 1999), both through hostility toward out-groups and preferential treatment toward in-groups (Portmann and Stojanović, 2022), the social meaning of discriminatory treatment cannot be fully understood solely through individual experiences of exclusion. The relevant question is therefore not only whether individuals personally experience discriminatory treatment, but also how they perceive the treatment of the broader social groups to which they belong. This distinction is reflected in the literature on the personal-group discrimination discrepancy (PGDD), which differentiates between perceptions of personal disadvantage and perceptions of discrimination directed against one's broader social group (Crosby, 1982; Taylor et al., 1990, 1996; Dion, 2001).

Taylor et al. (1996) argue that the personal-group discrimination discrepancy may arise through two complementary mechanisms. First, individuals may minimise or discount discrimination directed at themselves as a psychological coping strategy, thereby maintaining a sense of personal control and efficacy. Second, perceptions of discrimination against the broader group may be shaped by collective representations of disadvantage acquired through media exposure, public discourse, and awareness of discriminatory incidents affecting other group members. As a result, individuals may recognise substantial discrimination against their group while simultaneously evaluating their own circumstances more favourably.

While PGDD is well established in social psychology, housing-related evidence remains scarce and has focused mainly on Canada (Dion, 2001) and, more recently, Europe (Martiniello, 2025). To the best of our knowledge, this paper provides the first evidence of PGDD in a Japanese

housing-market context and suggests that perceptions of housing disadvantage are shaped not only by personal experiences but also by socially shared beliefs regarding group-level exclusion.

Our paper extends the PGDD framework into the context of housing discrimination. Unlike the previous studies on behavioural phenomena, this paper turns to social-cognitive phenomena by studying the perceived probabilistic status of housing access associated with different nationality groups in Tokyo’s rental housing market. Unlike most existing research, which examines realised discrimination through correspondence studies, we focus on subjective expectations of discrimination. While correspondence studies are highly valuable, differential treatment may reflect not only discriminatory preferences but also landlords’ statistical inferences about unobserved characteristics correlated with group signals such as names (Heckman, 1998).

Specifically, we investigate whether respondents perceive differential housing accessibility between nationality groups and whether these assessments differ between evaluations of one’s own prospects and those of broader social groups. We therefore adopt a complementary survey-experimental approach inspired by Lepinteur et al. (2025). Rather than observing realised outcomes directly, we elicit expectations about housing access from native Japanese and foreign-born residents. This allows us to study perceived discrimination and perceived in-group premia (Portmann and Stojanović, 2022) within Japan’s contemporary legal and institutional context.

An additional advantage of this approach is that respondents evaluate expected outcomes in the housing market rather than their own behaviour. This may reduce concerns about social desirability bias that often arise when studying discrimination based on sensitive social identities. More generally, the use of naturally occurring identity categories and third-party evaluations helps address external-validity concerns raised in experimental studies relying on artificial group assignments or direct measures of discriminatory behaviour (Lane, 2016).

To examine this, we implement a survey experiment in which respondents evaluate the likelihood that otherwise identical rental applicants receive a viewing invitation for the same property. Applicant characteristics are held constant except for ethnically identifiable names, allowing us to isolate perceived name-based discrimination across Japanese, Indonesian, Chinese, Western, Western-Japanese, Vietnamese, and South Korean profiles.

Our focus on perceived discrimination connects to a broader public-economics literature showing that subjective beliefs and biased perceptions can shape economically consequential preferences and decisions. For example, Cruces et al. (2013) use a survey experiment to show that biased perceptions of the income distribution affect redistributive preferences. In a similar spirit, our experiment studies beliefs about unequal access in the rental market: rather than measuring landlord behaviour directly, we examine how Japanese and foreign-born respondents perceive the likelihood that otherwise identical applicants receive access to housing.

We document five main findings. First, both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents expect non-Japanese applicants to face substantially lower viewing probabilities than otherwise identical Japanese applicants. Second, native respondents perceive significantly larger penalties, indicating systematic differences in how majority and minority groups assess the same market environment. Third, perceived disadvantage varies systematically across applicant groups and is smallest for Western-Japanese applicants, suggesting that perceived access is shaped not only by foreignness itself but also by signals of cultural proximity and partial insider status. Despite considerable heterogeneity across respondent nationalities, the Western-Japanese applicant is consistently evaluated more favourably than other non-Japanese profiles, highlighting the importance of perceived cultural proximity and insider status. Fourth, among foreign-born respondents, prior experiences of everyday discrimination are associated with more pessimistic expectations regarding rental access, while Japanese-language proficiency is posi-

tively associated with perceived access. Finally, respondents systematically evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group, consistent with the personal-group discrimination discrepancy and optimism bias in subjective expectations.

This paper contributes to the literature in three ways. First, it shifts attention from realised discrimination to subjective expectations of discrimination in housing markets. Unlike correspondence studies, which identify realised differential treatment, our approach captures how discrimination is socially perceived and anticipated by market participants themselves. Second, it provides new evidence on perceived discrimination in a non-Western housing market, where comparatively weak anti-discrimination protections coexist with strong tenant protections and long-term reliance on rental housing. This allows us to study perceived ethnic discrimination in a setting where access to rental housing is economically central, while legal constraints on exclusionary screening remain comparatively limited. Third, the paper contributes to the limited literature on the personal-group discrimination discrepancy in housing contexts. This study situates the discrepancy within Tokyo’s housing market and investigates how perceptions of individual and collective housing accessibility are structured across different nationality groups. By incorporating both majority and minority respondents, it further examines the extent to which perceptions of foreign disadvantage reflect socially shared expectations rather than perceptions confined to the affected group alone.

The remainder of the paper is organised as follows. section 2 discusses the historical, institutional, and legal background of Tokyo’s rental housing market. section 3 presents descriptive evidence of explicit exclusionary practices in the market. section 4 outlines the survey design and experimental methodology, while section 5 presents the empirical results. Finally, section 6 concludes. The Appendix provides additional supplementary materials.

2 Historical, Legal, and Institutional Context

2.1 Restrictive Immigration Policy and Ethnic Hierarchies in Japan

2.1.1 Labour Import Without ‘Immigration’

For decades, Japan denied the need for an immigration policy, instead implementing a system of de facto labour importation through side and back door entry while limiting pathways to long-term settlement and integration for foreign nationals (Vermillo Herman, 2021). In official discourse, the Japanese government has continued to reject the notion of ‘immigration,’ treating immigration as implying permanent settlement and integration (Hasegawa, 2023). Similar dynamics have been observed more broadly across East Asian migration regimes, where foreign workers are frequently incorporated as economically necessary labour while remaining socially and politically temporary populations (Bell and Piper, 2005). In such systems, migrants are often treated as labour market participants rather than prospective long-term members of the national community.

This distinction between labour admission and immigration resembles the broader logic of guestworker regimes, which admit foreign workers as a temporary and functionally necessary labour force while restricting claims to settlement, family life, and political membership (Surak, 2013). While the 2018 reform introduced two new visa categories — Specified Skilled Worker (SSW) Type 1 and 2 — explicitly recognising the need for lower-qualified labour (Chiavacci, 2025), former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe nevertheless stated during a Diet session on 29 October 2018³ that ‘the government has no intention to adopt a so-called immigration policy.’

³<https://mainichi.jp/english/articles/20181029/p2a/00m/0na/032000c>, last accessed in May 2026.

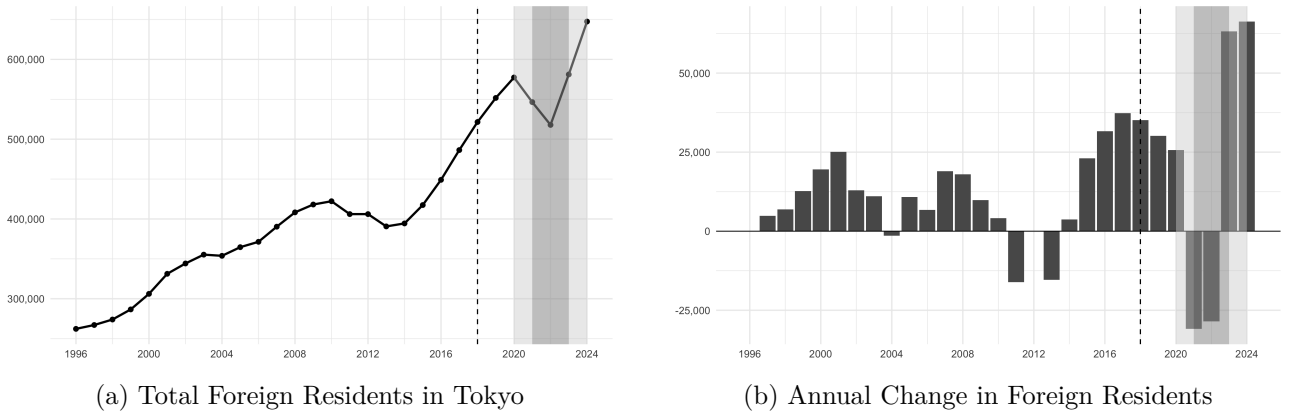
Despite this official framing, the reform marked a substantial shift in Japan’s migration regime. Chiavacci (2025) even characterises the reform as “a dam break in Japan’s immigration policy,” reflecting the disruptive nature of the institutional transition toward greater reliance on foreign labour. This transition increases the importance of understanding how foreign-born residents are perceived within key markets such as housing, where access depends heavily on private screening decisions.

2.1.2 Ethnic Hierarchies and Differential Integration

The 2018 reforms were primarily driven by demographic pressures, labour shortages, and co-ordinated business lobbying rather than a broader shift toward multicultural integration (Vermillo Herman, 2021). Despite institutional reforms, immigration policy in Japan continues to reflect ethnonationalist frameworks and differentiated perceptions of cultural compatibility (Shipper, 2016). Existing research suggests that immigrants are incorporated into a relatively clear ethnic hierarchy, in which co-ethnic and culturally proximate groups are often treated more favourably than other migrant populations (Tsuda, 1998). In the Japanese context, anti-immigrant attitudes are further found to be strongly shaped by concerns regarding identity and cultural homogeneity (Davison and Peng, 2021).

Figure 1 illustrates the increase in Tokyo’s foreign resident population following the 2018 immigration reform, despite a temporary slowdown during the COVID-19 period.

Figure 1: Foreign Residents in Tokyo, 1996–2024



Notes: The dashed vertical line marks the *2018 Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act* reform. Shaded areas indicate the COVID-19 period. The darker shaded region corresponds to years fully affected by pandemic-related restrictions, while lighter shaded regions correspond to partially affected years. Data are from the *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook*.

Corresponding figures for individual nationality groups are shown in Figure 6 in the Appendix.

2.2 Tenant-Protective Property Law and the Spatial Structure of Tokyo

Tokyo’s contemporary rental housing market is shaped by a historically entrenched system of strong tenant protections and long-term reliance on rental housing. Unlike housing systems in which renting primarily serves as a temporary stage before homeownership, renting constitutes a central and often long-term tenure form in Tokyo. This makes access to rental housing particularly important for social and economic integration, especially for foreign-born residents.

The institutional structure of Tokyo’s rental market reflects a longer historical development involving the evolution of tenant protections, the historical organisation of urban landholding, and postwar patterns of rental dependence. In particular, Japan’s strong tenant-protection regime, including automatic lease renewal and the “just cause” requirement, has historically encouraged relatively stable and long-term tenancy relations while also contributing to risk-averse screening behaviour among landlords. Additional historical background on the development of Tokyo’s rental housing market is provided in Appendix A.

Despite the introduction of fixed-term leases in 2000, much of Tokyo’s rental market remains structurally oriented toward relatively stable occupancy rather than short-term tenant turnover. Combined with comparatively low homeownership rates in Tokyo, this institutional structure increases the importance of equitable access to rental housing.

Existing research documents persistent socio-economic and spatial inequalities within Tokyo’s housing market. Although segregation levels are generally lower than in many Western metropolitan areas, disparities remain visible across occupational, income, and ethnic dimensions (Masaya, 2021; Fielding, 2004; Fujita and Hill, 2012). Foreign-born residents are concentrated in specific wards such as Shinjuku and Edogawa, reflecting both labour-market sorting and historical migration networks.⁴

Tokyo’s rental market therefore provides an important setting in which to study perceived discrimination. Access to rental housing is frequently mediated through private landlords and real-estate agents, creating substantial scope for unequal treatment at the screening stage. Existing studies further suggest that social perceptions and cultural proximity continue to shape attitudes toward foreign-born residents in Japan (Shipper, 2016).

2.3 Weak Anti-discrimination Law

2.3.1 Absence of Comprehensive Housing Anti-discrimination Law

Article 14 of the Japanese Constitution prohibits discrimination on several grounds, including race, creed, sex, social status, and family origin. Japan also became a party to the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (ICERD) in 1995, which entered into force domestically in 1996. In the housing context, Japanese courts have recognised certain forms of nationality-based differential treatment as unlawful under tort law and the principle of good faith in the Japanese Civil Code, particularly where landlords or real-estate agents refused to conclude tenancy agreements with non-Japanese applicants.⁵ More recently, the Tokyo District Court awarded damages against a real-estate agency that expressed unwillingness to rent to persons from a particular country.⁶

However, unlike the United Kingdom and European Union member states, Japan does not have statutory anti-discrimination provisions explicitly regulating differential treatment in the housing sector, nor an independent national human rights or equality body with monitoring/enforcement powers. In the United Kingdom, the *Equality Act 2010* expressly prohibits race discrimination in relation to the disposal and management of premises in the housing sector.⁷ At the European Union level, the *Racial Equality Directive* (2000/43/EC) requires Member States to prohibit discrimination in access to and supply of goods and services avail-

⁴Immigration Services Agency (2024) data indicate that Shinjuku has the largest foreign-born resident population among Tokyo’s 23 wards.

⁵Osaka High Court, 5 October 2006; Osaka High Court, 22 March 2007; Kyoto District Court, 2 October 2007.

⁶Tokyo District Court, 9 October 2019.

⁷Equality Act 2010, ss4, 9(1)(b), 13, 19, 26, 27 and 33-35.

able to the public, including housing, both in the public and private sector. The Directive further requires Member States to designate bodies for promotion of equal treatment and establish effective, proportionate, and dissuasive sanctions for infringements of anti-discrimination law.⁸ All Member States have now transposed this Directive to their national laws (European Commission, 2007).

A lack of statutory anti-discrimination provisions appears to be reflected in the continued public visibility of nationality-based screening language within the Japanese housing sector, as discussed in the following section. This contrasts with the position in jurisdictions such as the United Kingdom, the European Union, and the United States.⁹ Taking the United Kingdom as an example, race, including nationality, is a protected characteristic under anti-discrimination law,¹⁰ and the Equality and Human Rights Commission's Code of Practice treats advertisements expressing preferences or restrictions based on race or nationality amount to direct discrimination.¹¹ Accordingly, such advertisements are themselves unlawful, irrespective of whether any individual applicant can demonstrate discriminatory treatment in a particular transaction. Unlike indirect discrimination, which may be justified as a proportionate means of achieving a legitimate aim, direct race discrimination generally admits of no comparative justification defence.¹² Under UK equality law, deliberately segregating service users on racial grounds is treated as less favourable treatment.¹³ From this perspective, the existence of housing providers or property listings specifically marketed as suitable for foreign national would not necessarily resolve concerns about discrimination if their practical effect is to channel foreign applicants into separate segments of the housing market rather than ensuring equal access the market as a whole.

The United Nations' *Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination* repeatedly expressed concerns regarding discriminatory treatment by private actors in Japan, particularly discrimination in housing. The Committee has also criticised the absence of statutory provisions explicitly prohibiting racial discrimination, the lack of effective remedies, and weak institutional enforcement mechanisms.¹⁴ In response, the Japanese government argued that

⁸Art 3(1)(h), 13, 15.

⁹In the United States, the Fair Housing Act 42 USC §3604(c) explicitly prohibits discriminatory housing advertisements based on race or national origin.

¹⁰Equality Act 2010 s9; as to nationality, see s9(1)(b); *Mandla v Dowell Lee* [1983] AC 548; *Ealing LBC v CRE* [1972] AC 342.

¹¹Equality Act 2010 s13; Equality and Human Rights Commission, 'Guidance: Services, Public Functions and Associations: Code of Practice' (published 1 January 2011) 4.31 states 'If a service provider advertises that in offering a service they will treat applicants less favourably because of a protected characteristic, this would amount to direct discrimination'. Accessible at <https://www.equalityhumanrights.com/equality/equality-act-2010/codes-practice/services-public-functions-and-associations-code-0> In any case, under Equality Act 2006 s24A, the Commission has power to apply to the court for an injunction to deal with the publication of an advertisement suggesting that a service provider would discriminate (see the Code 14.61).

¹²cf. Equality Act 2010 s19(2)(d).

¹³Equality Act 2010 s 13(5).

¹⁴See Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations of the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination: Japan*, CERD/C/304/Add.114 (2001), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=lyJrHoSIHCA2RTKXgko4JqwonaM2kkcNfU6wkv17W5MYLT%2Bv2S5EYH9NmA5629puv7EaR830WENKIUUL4jc1H5tQi2u1ZbAKryD4rPoRvU8%3D>; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations of the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination: Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/3-6 (2010), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=izUhol7ZxPbJFSOWm%2F1jbKdvAC70A0joqH39rxwD%2FsYQ80FqNjArt%2BgGI6FwhLsR%2BHOf%2BiMsoHQxD9AuibXWA%3D%3D>; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations on the Combined Seventh to Ninth Periodic Reports of Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/7-9 (2014), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=eH37LT%2F%2Bv2S5EYH9NmA5629puv7EaR830WENKIUUL4jc1H5tQi2u1ZbAKryD4rPoRvU8%3D>

the *Human Rights Bureau* within the *Ministry of Justice* engages in protecting human rights.¹⁵ While the Bureau, originally established in 1948, explicitly recognises nationality-based exclusion in the housing market as a human-rights issue, it lacks institutional independence from the government and does not possess binding enforcement powers.

2.3.2 Hate Speech Regulation without Criminal Sanction

Because perceptions of discrimination are often influenced not only by direct experiences but also by publicly expressed exclusionary attitudes, the Japanese legal and regulatory treatment of discriminatory speech is also relevant to the present study. Japan maintains reservations to Article 4(b) and (c) of CERD, which require the criminalisation of certain forms of hate speech and racist organisations, citing concerns regarding freedom of expression. The Committee has repeatedly expressed concerns regarding racist and xenophobic speech in Japan.¹⁶

In response to growing domestic and international criticism, Japan enacted the *Hate Speech Act 2016*.¹⁷ However, the Act has a limited scope and lacks enforcement structure. The definition of prohibited conduct is relatively narrow, requiring speech or behaviour intended to promote or induce discriminatory sentiments or discriminatory behaviour (Art 2). Moreover, the Act does not impose any sanctions, instead providing only that 'citizens of Japan shall endeavour to deepen their understanding of the need to eliminate unfair discriminatory speech or behaviour' (Art 3). While Japanese courts have, in some cases, awarded damages against hate speech both offline and online,¹⁸ the CERD Committee has continued to express concerns regarding the absence of effective anti-hate speech enforcement mechanisms in Japan.¹⁹

Taken together, Japan's legal and institutional framework provides comparatively limited constraints on nationality-based exclusion in private rental markets. While courts have occasionally recognised particularly explicit forms of discrimination as unlawful, the absence of comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation and effective enforcement mechanisms leaves substantial discretion to landlords and real-estate agents in screening prospective tenants.

However, the Japanese government maintains that discrimination against non-Japanese residents was not sufficiently severe to require comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation or criminal sanctions. It stated that 'We do not recognize that the present situation of Japan is one in which discriminative act cannot be effectively restrained by the existing legal system...', thereby maintaining that the existing Japanese legal framework was sufficient to address dis-

2BEGaGZEmrzoZ0Bddj8Jx71StPMHnyoeIwYtHVqaweoS%2F%2FM7RevYJU%2BKbVsT5V0FJoEqW2Avpbo%2FLTbw%3D%3D; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations on the Combined Tenth and Eleventh Periodic Reports of Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/10-11 (2018), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=cSiLKueF08pNvNu3RBjBpHu596d6AmEKyPsxtP5iedXv%2F1H9b8G03JWV4wBKUZ2uVwJCQ%2FBBEpk4BWzF3NPswSunJwsZ8oB%2F6pY7tcdcw%3D>.

¹⁵Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Information Received from Japan on Follow-up to the Concluding Observations*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/10-11/Add.1 (2019), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=%2BTnmP2Rfpf5TFx0TwIkDW0rxS6g0v7bNqxQ1hx%2Fa6i%2F0TwuUXfnDt1habGcxZanbpGTH9jbsgcHLfAUyrqLW1NB%2Bon%2Fg3nSq7UOSnjG85zc%3D>

¹⁶See note 8.

¹⁷Act of the Promotion of Efforts to Eliminate Unfair Discriminatory Speech and Behaviour against Persons Originating from Outside Japan (2016).

¹⁸For instance, the Kyoto District Court (7 October 2013) awarded damages against an extremist anti-Korean organisation whose members repeatedly used loudspeakers near a Korean school to disseminate discriminatory and derogatory speech targeting ethnic Koreans. More recently, the Tokyo High Court (12 May 2021) awarded damages that were relatively high by Japanese tort law standards against a blogger, who had posted discriminatory and derogatory comments against ethnic Koreans.

¹⁹See *Concluding Observations on the Combined Tenth and Eleventh Periodic Reports of Japan* (2018), in note 11.

criminary conduct without further legislative intervention.²⁰ The following section therefore examines whether exclusionary practices remain observable in Tokyo’s contemporary rental market.

3 Visibility of Nationality-Related Signalling in Tokyo’s Real Estate Market

The institutional context discussed above suggests that discriminatory behaviour toward foreigners in Japan’s rental market may persist more openly than in many other developed economies, thereby shaping perceptions among both foreign and native residents. Before turning to our main contribution – the measurement of subjectively perceived discrimination against foreigners in Tokyo’s rental housing market – we first provide objective evidence that exclusionary practices remain a persistent and visible feature of the market today.

First, qualitative evidence from journalistic reporting highlights the continued prevalence of discriminatory treatment toward foreign residents in the housing sector.²¹ The article documents repeated cases in which foreign residents were denied housing applications solely on the basis of nationality, despite meeting standard financial and contractual requirements. It further reports that real estate agents frequently justify these exclusions by citing landlords’ concerns about communication barriers, cultural differences, or perceived risks associated with non-Japanese tenants. Importantly, the article emphasizes that such practices persist partly because Japan lacks comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation specifically prohibiting nationality-based exclusion in the housing market. Interviews with affected residents and housing advocates suggest that discriminatory screening practices are sufficiently common to constitute a well-recognized obstacle for foreigners seeking accommodation in major urban areas.

Second, we provide quantitative evidence by a visibility-based method examining how references to foreign tenants appear in publicly discoverable search across major Japanese real estate platforms: SUUMO, LIFULL HOME’S, and at home.²² During our observation window between May 22–24, 2026, the three platforms jointly hosted more than 14.8 million listings, with SUUMO being the largest platform (approximately 7.56 million listings), followed by HOME’S (5.02 million) and at home (2.24 million). Using Google site-restricted searches conducted from a UK IP address, we searched the free-text content of listings for multiple Japanese-language terms associated with the explicit exclusion, consideration or explicit inclusion of foreign applicants, including 外国籍不可 (“foreign nationals not allowed”), 外国人不可 (“foreigners not allowed”), 外国籍相談 (“foreign nationals negotiable”), 外国人相談 (“foreigners negotiable”), 外国籍可 (“foreign nationals allowed”), 外国人可 (“foreigners allowed”), 外国籍歓迎 (“foreign nationals welcome”), and 外国人歓迎 (“foreigners welcome”), both nationwide and for the Greater Tokyo area.

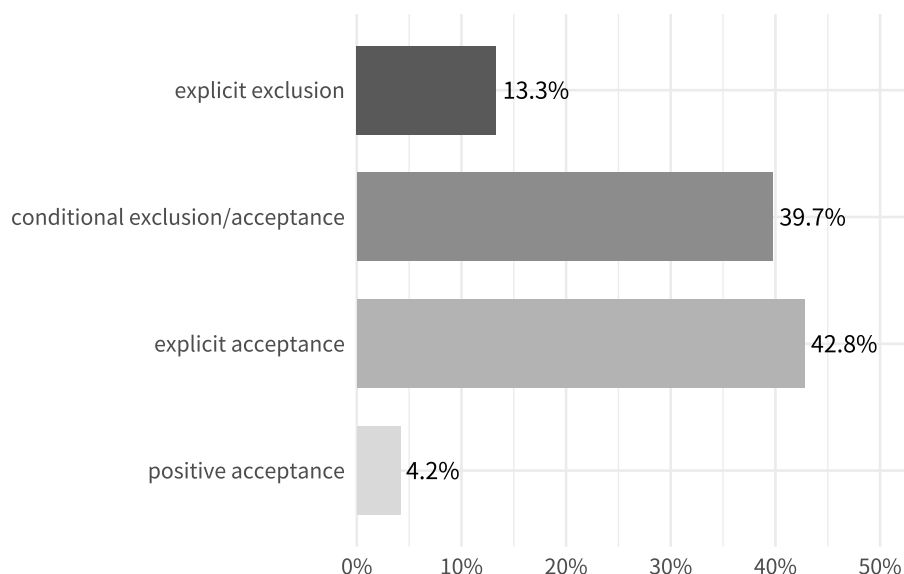
Among those adverts that do contain such references, we can therefore assess the relative prevalence of exclusionary, conditional, and explicitly inclusive language. Results shown in Figure 2 indicate that the use of explicit exclusionary language remains widespread. In our sample,

²⁰Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, *Comments of the Japanese Government on the Concluding Observations Adopted by the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination on March 20, 2000, Regarding Initial and Second Periodic Report of the Japanese Government* (2000), available at: <https://www.mofa.go.jp/policy/human/comment0110.html>.

²¹Shaun McKenna, “What’s Behind Housing Discrimination in Japan?,” *The Japan Times*, May 31, 2021, <https://www.japantimes.co.jp/community/2021/05/31/how-tos/housing-discrimination-still-problem-japan/>.

²²SUUMO: <https://suumo.jp>; HOME’S: <https://www.homes.co.jp>; at home: <https://www.athome.co.jp>.

Figure 2: Distribution of Nationality-Related Rental Listing Search Results



Notes: The Figure aggregates search terms cross platforms and into four categories: explicit exclusion, conditional exclusion/acceptance, explicit acceptance, and positive acceptance. Shares are calculated relative to all relevant search results returned by the platform-specific Google searches.

13.3% of all advertisements across the three platforms contained clearly exclusionary wording, suggesting that such practices are not isolated incidents but rather a commonly observable feature of the housing market. An additional 39.7% of advertisements were only conditionally willing to accept foreigners, whereas 46.9% were unconditionally open to foreign tenants.

While the vast majority of adverts do not contain any of these nationality-related terms, explicit references to foreign applicants do exist and, importantly, such statements are not prohibited in Japan (see subsection 2.3). This contrasts with a number of other developed economies where equality legislation prohibit nationality-based screening in property advertisements, as discussed in the previous section. In some jurisdictions, protection extends beyond race, nationality and other traditional protected grounds. For example, following a successful proceedings brought by the Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission in 2019, Irish rental advertisements may no longer specify preferred tenant characteristics based on family status or receipt of housing allowance.²³ Although Ireland's framework reflects the EU *Racial Equality Directive*, it extends protection beyond the Directive's minimum requirements. In comparative perspectives, the nationality-based signalling within Japanese property market would be regarded as illegal discrimination or at least its strong indicator.

The significance of these findings lies not primarily in the prevalence of such advertisements, but in their visibility, which may itself be consequential. Even where such language does not necessarily reflect the intentions of other landlords, its repeated appearance within publicly accessible search results may itself contribute to perceptions of different treatment and social inclusion. Housing discrimination frequently operates through subtle and discretionary mechanisms rather than explicit exclusion. Prospective tenants may encounter non-responses, differential treatment during enquiries, additional documentary requirements, non-invitation at the viewing stage, or opaque selection decisions. In such settings, unequal treatment is often

²³See "Rental ads can no longer specify preferred tenants as IHREC wins equality case," *Law Society Gazette*, August 2019, <https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2019/08-august/rental-ads-can-no-longer-specify-preferred-tenants-as-ihrec-wins-equality-case>.

difficult to identify from individual transaction alone.

While our visibility search provide evidence that nationality-based exclusion remains present in Tokyo’s rental market, they do not reveal how such practices are perceived by market participants themselves. The visibility of nationality-related language is open to more than one interpretation. On one view, such advertisements may represent isolated expectations within an otherwise open rental market. On other, explicit acceptance language may itself indicate that differential treatment is sufficiently expected that landlords willing to rent to foreign applicants must actively signal their openness. Under this latter interpretation, references such as ‘foreign nationals negotiable’ may suggest that equal access cannot be assumed as the market baseline.

Yet, perceptions of discrimination are economically important in their own right, as anticipated unequal treatment may influence housing search behaviour, application strategies, housing choices and finally also broader expectations of social inclusion.

For this reason, the study proceeds to a experiment designed to identify perceived responses to applicants of different foreign backgrounds in so as to more directly identify the embedded social norms against which those listing language operates. Importantly, this also allows us to understand whether or not these discriminatory practises are perceived equally across different groups of the Japanese society.

More generally, stated expectations in the present setting may capture both descriptive beliefs about how landlords and agents are likely to behave and injunctive beliefs regarding the social acceptability of exclusionary screening practices. Experimental evidence suggests that discriminatory behaviour is shaped not only by private preferences, but also by prevailing social norms concerning the appropriateness of discrimination (Barr et al., 2018). In institutional environments where anti-discrimination norms are comparatively weak or ambiguously enforced, respondents’ expectations may therefore reflect both anticipated market behaviour and broader perceptions regarding which forms of exclusion are socially tolerated.

We therefore next turn to the design of our survey experiment, which measures how native Japanese and foreign-born residents perceive the likelihood that applicants of different ethnic backgrounds receive access to rental housing.

4 Survey Design

4.1 Technical Implementation and Quality Assurance

A cross-sectional online survey was administered between April and May 2025 using the Japanese panel provider *GMO Research*. The survey targeted residents of the Greater Tokyo area and employed quota sampling to recruit approximately 800 Japanese nationals and 200 foreign-born residents. Foreign-born respondents were oversampled to ensure sufficient statistical power for subgroup analyses.

The questionnaire was implemented through Qualtrics and included multiple data-quality safeguards, including minimum completion-time thresholds, response-completeness checks, location validation, and duplicate-response prevention. After applying these validity filters, a small number of observations was excluded due to incomplete or inconsistent responses. Implementation details are summarised in Appendix B.

Ethical approval was obtained from the Department of Land Economy, and informed consent was secured from all participants prior to participation.

4.2 Development of Fictitious Rental Applicants

Applicant profiles were constructed using *Japanese Immigration Agency* (2024) data to reflect the composition of migrant inflows following the 2018 immigration reforms. To isolate perceived discrimination, profiles differed only in ethnically identifiable names while all other applicant characteristics were held constant. Applicant names were pre-tested for ethnic recognisability and standardised using Japanese script conventions to preserve comparability across profiles. Table 1 reports the final applicant profiles.

Table 1: Applicant Profiles

Name	Ethnicity	Native Translation	Katakana Characters
Taro Yamamoto	Japanese	山本太郎	山本太郎
Andi Surya Purta	Indonesian	Andi Surya Purta	アンディ・スルヤ・プトラ
Wei Chang	Chinese	张伟	ウェイ・チャン
Thomas Laurent	Western	Thomas Laurent	トーマ・ローラン
James Takeda	Japanese-Western	James Takeda	ジェームズ・武田
Nguyễn Văn Minh	Vietnamese	Nguyễn Văn Minh	グエン・ヴァン・ミン
Park-Ji Hoon	Korean	박지훈	パク・ジフン

Notes: Native scripts are shown where applicable; Katakana is used to standardise the rendering of non-Japanese names.

The Western-Japanese profile is included to distinguish perceived responses to foreignness from perceived responses to partial cultural or ethnic proximity. Unlike the Western profile, the Western-Japanese applicant combines a Western given name with a Japanese surname, thereby signalling both foreign association and potential insider status. This profile allows us to examine whether perceived rental access is shaped by a binary Japanese/non-Japanese distinction or by more graduated ethnic boundaries. If respondents evaluate the Western-Japanese applicant more favourably than other non-Japanese applicants, this would suggest that perceived discrimination is moderated by cues of cultural familiarity, partial assimilation, or proximity to the Japanese majority group.

Further details on name construction, validation procedures, script standardisation, and translation protocols are provided in Appendix C.

4.3 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire comprised three sections. The first collected respondents' socio-economic characteristics. The second asked participants to evaluate the likelihood of each applicant securing a rental viewing for a standardised property. The third, administered only to foreign-born residents, included a condensed version of the Everyday Discrimination Scale (Williams et al., 1997), adapted to capture perceived discrimination in rental access and search strategies.

The survey was developed in English and translated into Japanese using machine translation, followed by verification by four native speakers. This process ensured linguistic accuracy and minimised potential bias in the evaluation tasks.

Section 1: Socio-Economic Characteristics. Questions to elicit socio-economic variables were drawn from established government sources.²⁴ The official questionnaires are available in

²⁴The questions were taken from the *Ministry of Justice Basic Foreign Residents Survey* (<https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001421198.pdf>), the *2020 National Census* (<https://www.stat.go.jp/english/>)

English and Japanese. Hence, no translation bias is expected.

Where necessary, supplemental measures were incorporated using standardised national benchmarks, including income deciles from the *2024 National Family Expenditure and Income Survey* and ethnicity classifications adapted from the *CIA World Factbook*. As ethnicity is not typically captured in Japanese surveys, questions were designed using broad, participant-selectable groupings and reviewed for cultural sensitivity by native Japanese academics.

The following variables were included as independent predictors: economic (income, industry, employment status, housing status) and cultural (gender, age, ethnicity, education level), with additional variables for foreign-born residents only (visa status, length of residence, and language proficiency).

Questions were harmonised across groups using *Qualtrics* branching logic, excluding non-applicable variables for Japanese respondents to maintain comparability. Variables such as visa status, language proficiency, and length of residence are central to testing the integration paradox in the Tokyo context (Steinmann, 2019), while prior international exposure among Japanese respondents (e.g., study abroad) may moderate susceptibility to societal bias (Tomiura et al., 2019).

Section 2: Perceived Likelihood of Securing a Rental Viewing. This section aims to elicit participants’ subjectively perceived likelihood of different people being invited to a viewing. Therefore, participants are shown a rental listing together with one of the profiles developed in subsection 4.2. At the end, participants are also asked to assess the probability that they themselves would be offered a viewing. The same listing was used throughout the entire experiment.

We consistently elicit the perceived likelihood on a 11-step Likert scale as shown in Figure 3. A neutral question design was employed to reduce priming or coercion.

The property listing used was sourced from *LIFULL Homes*,²⁵ one of the largest real estate websites in Japan and the experimental platform of choice also used by Sugawara and Harano (2023). The selected property is located in the Tokyo ward with the median number of foreign-born residents according to official statistics. It is a one room apartment, in keeping with the applicant profile portraying a single male, with a rent of 60,000 yen per calendar month, which is the average for a property in this area (according to 2020 data from the National Association of Real Estate Transactions). The purpose of the property listing is to anchor respondents’ expectations and provide a degree of familiarity where they may be caught off guard by the question style (Weiss and Roberts, 2018).

Section 3: Everyday Discrimination Scale (EDS). This section was displayed to foreign-born resident respondents only. Respondents were presented four questions (printed in Appendix D) from the EDS survey used to validate perceived discrimination levels. Precisely, participants are asked to rate how often they experience four types of discriminatory situations. This allows us to compile an standardised and comparable measure of discrimination experienced by participants.

We use this measure in two ways. First, we test whether the EDS score correlates with objective proxies of integration such as legal status (permanent visa), length of stay, and Japanese language proficiency. Second, the design allows us to test whether perceived discrimination differs between assessments of one’s own prospects and assessments of one’s broader nationality

data/kokusei/2020/summary.html), and the *National Survey of Family Income, Consumption and Wealth* (<https://www.stat.go.jp/english/data/zenkokukakei/index.html>).

²⁵See <https://www.homes.co.jp/>.

Figure 3: Eliciting the Perceived Likelihood to be Invited



UNIVERSITY OF
CAMBRIDGE

English (United Kingdom) ▾

PR Rental Apartment Village Enomoto 302/ 3rd floor



Rent/management fee, etc.	Location	Transportation	Exclusive area/floor plan
60,000 yen	3-2-11 Minamidai, Nakano-ku, Tokyo	12-minute walk from Nakano Fujimicho Station on the Tokyo Metro Marunouchi Line	15.71 square meters One room

Wei Chang has just moved to Tokyo; he wants to rent the above property. He contacted the landlord and asked to view the property. What do you think is the chance of him being invited to a viewing?

0102030405060708090100

Chance of being invited for a viewing (%)

Notes: The figure shows a snapshot of the experimental screens presented to participants to elicit their subjective perceptions of the likelihood of being invited to a viewing.

group.

Specifically, we anticipate that the probability an individual assigns to their ethnic category will be lower than the probability they assign to themselves due to the well-documented personal-group discrimination discrepancy (PGDD). Emerging from relative deprivation theory, early studies on PGDD showed that working White women reported lower levels of personal than group-based discrimination in employment and income contexts (Crosby, 1982). This pattern has subsequently been replicated across racial, ethnic, and gender groups in multiple countries. Dion (2001) first documents the effect in the context of perceived discrimination in the rental housing market, focusing on Canada.

The selected EDS items capture courtesy, receipt of poorer service relative to others, perceptions of being feared, and perceptions of being viewed as dishonest. These measures were chosen for their relevance to landlord decision-making in offering property viewings (Clark, 2007; Hamovitch et al., 2022; Hanson et al., 2011). Responses are elicited on a Likert scale and re-coded to a linear scale for processing (almost every day = 5 to never = 0), before being aggregated into a composite index of perceived everyday discrimination.

5 Empirical Analyses

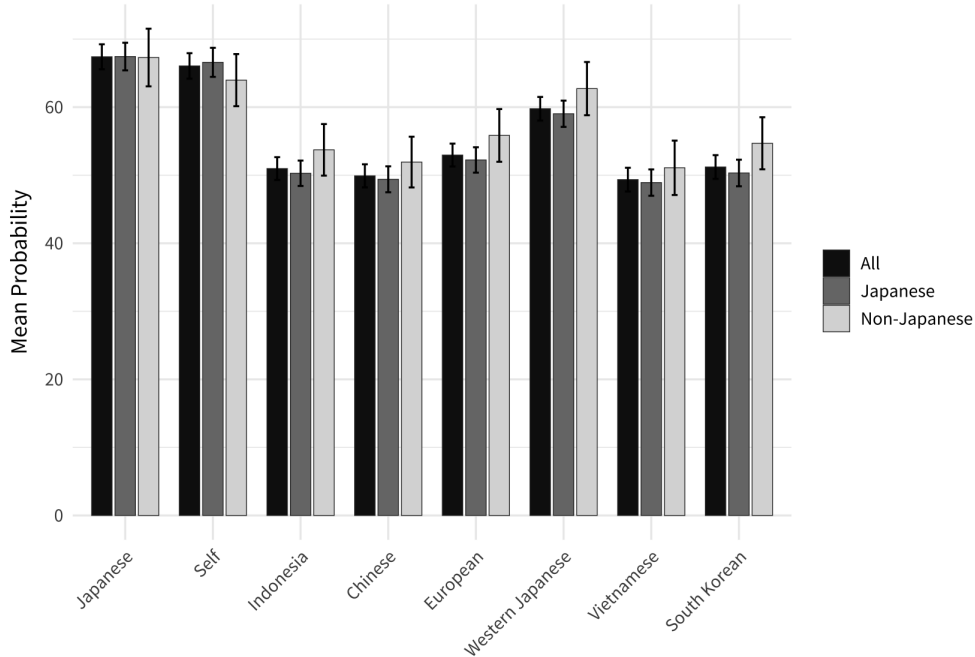
5.1 Evidence of Perceived Discrimination in Tokyo’s Housing Market

5.1.1 Do Native and Foreign-born Residents in Tokyo expect Discrimination of Non-Japanese Rental Applicants?

We first focus on assessing the sample²⁶ of native Japanese residents and their perceptions. We compute an overall average perceived probability of applicants (excluding oneself) being invited to a viewing of 54.7% (median: 55.7%). These probabilities are significantly lower when the native Japanese applicant is excluded, falling to 52.4% (median: 52.2%).

Splitting responses by applicants’ ethnic background reveals substantial heterogeneity, as shown in Figure 4. Japanese respondents expect all non-Japanese applicants to face a significantly lower probability of receiving a viewing invitation than the Japanese applicant, with all differences statistically significant at the 1% level. The largest perceived disadvantages are observed for Vietnamese, Chinese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, while the Western applicant is evaluated somewhat more favourably. The Western-Japanese applicant receives the most favourable evaluation among all non-Japanese profiles. This pattern suggests that perceived housing access is shaped not only by foreignness itself but also by signals of cultural proximity and partial insider status.

Figure 4: Mean stated viewing probabilities.



Notes: Collectively stated average probabilities of applicants of different ethnic backgrounds being offered a viewing. Overall probabilities as well as splits by native Japanese and foreign-born participants. Bars indicate standard deviations.

To assess the substantive importance of these differences, we compute Cohen’s d as a standard-

²⁶Table 9 in the Appendix reports summary statistics.

ised measure of deviation from the Japanese benchmark. The estimates indicate that Japanese respondents perceive stronger disadvantages for non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents. Among Japanese respondents, effect sizes are moderate to large ($d > 0.5$), with Indonesian and Chinese applicants positioned 0.71 and 0.67 standard deviations below the Japanese benchmark, respectively. Corresponding effects among foreign-born respondents are smaller at 0.55 and 0.59. By contrast, the Western-Japanese applicant yields comparatively small effect sizes in both groups ($d = 0.40$ among Japanese respondents and $d = 0.21$ among foreign-born respondents). Finally, the effect size for self-perceived probability is negligible, suggesting that respondents in both groups evaluate their own prospects as broadly comparable to those of the Japanese applicant.

Assessing the relative ranking of applicant groups, native Japanese and foreign-born respondents exhibit broad agreement regarding the most favourably evaluated categories. Most notably, both groups attribute the highest likelihood to themselves. While the difference relative to the Japanese applicant remains negative, it is not statistically distinguishable from zero.

Differences between the two groups emerge only among the lowest-ranked categories. Japanese respondents rank Chinese applicants above Vietnamese and Indonesian applicants, assigning Indonesians the lowest position overall. In contrast, foreign-born respondents rank Indonesians above Vietnamese and Chinese applicants, while Chinese applicants receive the lowest ranking in this group.

Nationality-specific analyses reported in Table 10 in the Appendix reveal substantial heterogeneity within the foreign-born sample. While respondents differ considerably in their relative evaluations of Chinese, Vietnamese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, the comparatively favourable assessment of the Western-Japanese applicant is remarkably consistent across respondent nationalities. Overall, these findings suggest that perceived housing access is structured less by a universally shared hierarchy among foreign groups than by broad distinctions in perceived cultural proximity and insider status. The stable advantage attributed to the Western-Japanese profile therefore suggests that respondents perceive access through graded boundaries of belonging rather than a simple Japanese/non-Japanese divide.²⁷

To assess the importance of differences, we compute Cohen’s d to achieve a standardized measure of deviations. Again, the Japanese applicant *Taro Yamamoto* acts as benchmark as this applicant is ranked top in terms of viewing invitation likelihood Table 2. The Cohen’s d estimates indicate that Japanese nationals perceive stronger bias relative to foreign-born respondents when the Japanese baseline is standardised. Among Japanese respondents, effect sizes are moderate to large ($d > 0.5$), with Indonesian and Chinese applicants positioned 0.71 and 0.67 standard deviations below the baseline, respectively. In the foreign-born respondents subsample, these effects are attenuated (0.55 and 0.59). By contrast, the Western-Japanese applicant yields a small effect size ($d < 0.5$) across both groups, yet again smaller in size among foreign-born respondents. Finally, the effect size for self-perceived probability is negligible, suggesting that respondents in both subsamples evaluate their own prospects as broadly comparable to those of Japanese applicants.

As shown in Figure 5, all non-Japanese profiles are evaluated less favourably than the Japanese

²⁷As an additional robustness check, we reweighted the full sample so that the nationality composition of survey respondents matches the corresponding population shares of Tokyo residents by nationality, using data from the Tokyo Statistical Yearbook (2024), <https://www.toukei.metro.tokyo.lg.jp/tnenkan/2024/tn24q3e002.htm>. The resulting estimates are qualitatively identical to those obtained for the native population. This similarity is unsurprising given the relatively small share of foreign residents in Tokyo. Consequently, the results based on the native population provide a close approximation to the perceptions of Tokyo’s population as a whole.

Table 2: Differences in Perceived Likelihood of Viewing Invitations by Origin

	Indonesian	Chinese	Western Nationals	Western Japanese	Vietnamese	South Korean	Self- Perceived
Japanese							
Probability (%)	50.28	49.40	52.24	59.03	48.91	50.33	66.58
Difference from Japanese (%)	-17.12***	-17.90***	-15.16***	-8.44***	-18.59***	-17.18***	-0.95
Cohen's <i>d</i>	0.71	0.67	0.62	0.40	0.69	0.65	0.04
<i>N</i>	788	785	783	780	776	772	773
Non-Japanese							
Probability (%)	53.73	51.93	55.85	62.72	51.09	54.69	63.97
Difference from Japanese (%)	-13.57***	-15.57***	-11.48***	-4.61***	-16.24***	-12.64***	-3.36
Cohen's <i>d</i>	0.55	0.59	0.45	0.21	0.57	0.47	0.11
<i>N</i>	198	197	195	195	195	195	195

Notes: Entries report paired comparisons between the Japanese applicant (Taro Yamamoto) and each target applicant. “Probability” gives the mean perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation for the target applicant. “Difference from Japanese” is calculated as target applicant probability minus Japanese applicant probability; negative values therefore indicate a lower perceived likelihood than for the Japanese applicant. Cohen’s *d* is based on the paired difference between the Japanese applicant and the target applicant. *N* varies slightly across comparisons because each estimate uses respondents with complete paired responses for the relevant applicant pair. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

benchmark. The most striking feature of the ranking is the stable position of the Western-Japanese applicant immediately below the Japanese benchmark in both respondent groups, making it the highest-ranked non-Japanese profile. Both groups further evaluate the Western applicant and the South Korean applicant relatively favourably compared with the remaining non-Japanese categories.

The Western-Japanese profile combines a Western given name with a Japanese surname, signalling both foreign association and partial insider status. The comparatively favourable evaluation of the Western-Japanese applicant is theoretically important because it suggests that perceived rental access is not governed solely by a binary distinction between Japanese and non-Japanese applicants (see also Pager and Shepherd, 2008). Rather, respondents appear to distinguish between varying degrees of cultural proximity and social closeness to the Japanese majority. This pattern is consistent with research showing that discrimination often operates through socially graded boundaries of perceived cultural proximity and assimilability rather than through simple majority-minority distinctions.

Differences between the two groups emerge only among the lowest-ranked categories. Japanese respondents rank Chinese applicants above Vietnamese and Indonesian applicants, assigning Indonesians the lowest position overall. In contrast, foreign-born respondents rank Indonesians above Vietnamese and Chinese applicants, while Chinese applicants receive the lowest ranking in this group.

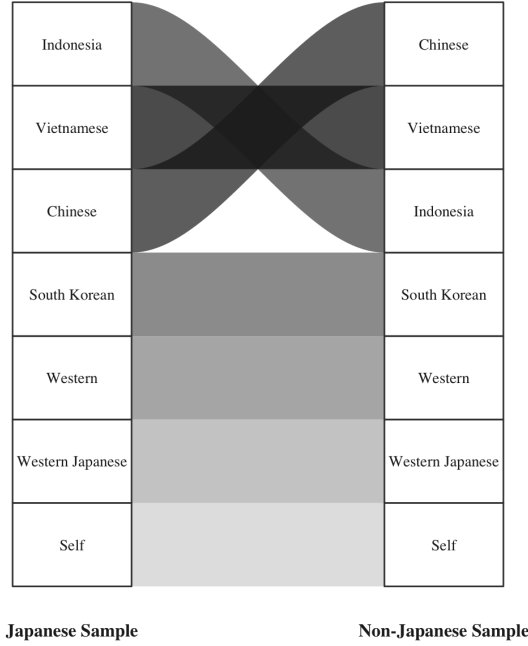
Nationality-specific analyses reported in Table 10 in the Appendix reveal substantial heterogeneity within the foreign-born sample. While respondents differ considerably in their relative evaluations of Chinese, Vietnamese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, the comparatively favourable assessment of the Western-Japanese applicant is remarkably consistent across respondent nationalities. Overall, these findings suggest that perceived housing access is structured less by a universally shared hierarchy among foreign groups than by broad distinctions in perceived cultural proximity and insider status. The stable advantage attributed to the Western-Japanese profile therefore suggests that respondents perceive access through graded boundaries of belonging rather than a simple Japanese/non-Japanese divide.

Table 3: Perceived Likelihood of Viewing Invitations

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Constant	67.406*** (0.935)		
Chinese	-17.500*** (0.851)	-17.387*** (0.674)	-15.458*** (1.502)
Western Nationals	-14.446*** (0.799)	-14.349*** (0.675)	-11.401*** (1.507)
Indonesia	-16.430*** (0.776)	-16.407*** (0.673)	-13.566*** (1.499)
South Korean	-16.199*** (0.857)	-16.117*** (0.677)	-12.555*** (1.507)
Vietnamese	-18.055*** (0.878)	-17.999*** (0.676)	-16.160*** (1.507)
Western Japanese	-7.639*** (0.684)	-7.580*** (0.675)	-4.524*** (1.507)
Self	-1.348* (0.779)	-1.308* (0.677)	-3.278** (1.507)
Chinese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-2.414 (1.680)
Western $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.686** (1.685)
Indonesia $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.555** (1.677)
South Korean $\times$ Japanese respondent			-4.458*** (1.686)
Vietnamese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-2.300 (1.686)
Western Japanese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.821** (1.685)
Self $\times$ Japanese respondent			2.470 (1.686)
Respondents FE	.	✓	✓
Clustered SE by Respondents	✓	.	.
Adj. R^2	0.058	0.079	0.082
F -statistic	69.16***	238.85***	121.70***
Observations	7820	7820	7820

Notes: The reference category for applicants' nationality is Japanese (Taro Yamamoto). * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure 5: Ranking Shifts in Cohen’s d by Origin



Notes: Rankings are based on Cohen’s d from paired comparisons between the Japanese candidate and each comparison profile in perceived likelihood of viewing an invitation. Rank 1 (at the bottom) indicates the smallest negative deviation. The right column shows native Japanese respondents; the left column shows non-Japanese respondents.

In addition to univariate comparisons, we next test for systematic differences within a multivariate regression framework (see Table 3). Model (1) regresses stated likelihoods on applicants’ nationality without additional controls. The estimated coefficients closely mirror the averages reported in Table 2. We cluster standard errors at the participant level to account for within-participant correlation in responses.

Model (2) accounts for participant-specific baseline levels in stated likelihoods by incorporating individual fixed effects. This specification absorbs all time-invariant respondent characteristics that could influence overall response levels. While the model’s explanatory power naturally increases, the inclusion of fixed effects has no substantive impact on the estimated coefficients for the different ethnic groups, reinforcing the robustness of the findings.

Finally, Model (3) interacts applicants’ nationality with a dummy for Japanese respondents, allowing us to assess systematic differences in how natives and foreign-born respondents perceive the likelihoods associated with different applicant types. A Wald test confirms that this distinction is important, as stated probabilities differ significantly between the two groups ($\chi^2_7 = 27.006$, $p = 0.0003^{***}$).

Consistent with the univariate comparisons in Table 2, the results indicate that native respondents assign even lower likelihoods to non-Japanese applicants. This pattern is driven in particular by lower probabilities attributed to Western, Indonesian, South Korean, and Western Japanese applicants.

Notably, while foreign-born respondents show relatively little differentiation between Western Japanese and Japanese applicants, native respondents place substantially greater weight on this distinction, possibly reflecting a deeper sensitivity to cultural nuances that may be less apparent to non-Japanese observers. South Korean applicants occupy an intermediate position

in the perceived hierarchy. While Japanese respondents assign them lower viewing probabilities than the Western Japanese and Western applicants, they evaluate them more favourably than Chinese, Vietnamese, and Indonesian applicants. This pattern may reflect the coexistence of historical tensions and relatively high levels of cultural familiarity between Japan and South Korea.

Similarly, applicants of Western and Indonesian origin are attributed a significantly lower likelihood by native Japanese participants. While in the univariate assessment natives and immigrants perceived no significant differences in chances between themselves and the Japanese applicant, the multivariate structure clearly identifies significantly lower perceived chances by immigrants than natives, which is consistent with the overall highest likelihood attributed to the Japanese applicant.

Several explanations may account for the finding of these differences between natives and immigrants in perceptions. Differences may reflect distinct historical reference points, with Japanese respondents drawing on longer-term observations formed during periods when foreign residents were more marginalised within the housing market, as discussed in subsection 2.1. They may also reflect differences in normative understandings of discrimination or varying levels of awareness regarding legal and recent policy developments affecting foreign residents, as discussed in subsection 2.3.

A further possibility is that foreign-born respondents adapt their housing search behaviour to existing market conditions. As suggested by our visibility-based inquiry in section 3, foreign applicants may rely disproportionately on agencies, landlords, or housing channels explicitly signalling to accommodate foreign tenants. To the extent that foreign-born respondents' perceptions are formed within these small, but accessible segment of the market, they may underestimate the extent to which foreign applicants encounter barriers elsewhere in the housing sector, thereby contributing to lower estimates of disadvantage.

5.2 The Role of Participants' Socio-Economic Characteristics

Having established that non-Japanese applicants are perceived to face lower chances of securing a viewing, we next collapse all non-Japanese profiles into a single 'Non-Japanese Applicants' (NJA) category and examine heterogeneity by respondents' characteristics. Table 4 reports the results.²⁸ Model (1) reaffirms the baseline findings obtained with separate non-Japanese applicant categories: Participants jointly expect a lower chance of NJAs to secure a viewing as compared to the Japanese applicant. Model (2) confirms again that Japanese respondents perceive a significantly larger penalty for non-native applicants than non-Japanese respondents. Model (3) tests for differences by gender. Perceived discrimination appears not to differ between female and male participants.

Model (4) splits the sample at the median age. Older respondents expect higher viewing probabilities overall, but they also perceive a significantly larger disadvantage for NJAs. The findings for gender and age are in line with results from Luxembourg based on revealed discrimination rather than stated perceptions (Lepinteur et al., 2025). The finding that older Japanese participants perceive stronger disadvantages for NJAs may be driven by several mechanisms. The age gradient may reflect experience-based learning, cohort effects, or differential exposure to recent market developments. Distinguishing between these mechanisms is beyond the scope of the present design and remains an avenue for future research.

Model (5) indicates that lower-income respondents anticipate less discrimination against NJAs,

²⁸We cluster standard errors at the respondent-level. Controlling for individual FE again leads to very similar marginal effects.

Table 4: Heterogeneity Results

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	67.406*** (0.934)	67.293*** (2.158)	66.201*** (1.253)	64.805*** (1.344)	68.010*** (1.355)	64.165*** (1.547)
NJA	-15.046*** (0.739)	-12.301*** (1.658)	-14.701*** (0.995)	-13.352*** (1.042)	-16.487*** (1.037)	-12.656*** (1.234)
Japanese respondent		0.141 (2.393)				
NJA $\times$ Japanese respondent		-3.434* (1.851)				
Female			2.911 (1.873)			
NJA $\times$ Female			-0.828 (1.478)			
Age > 50				5.263** (1.860)		
NJA $\times$ (Age > 50)				-3.504** (1.474)		
Income = Below Median					-1.189 (1.870)	
NJA $\times$ (Income = Below Median)					2.842* (1.474)	
Degree						5.417** (1.932)
NJA $\times$ Degree						-4.005** (1.533)
Clustered SE by Respondents	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Adj. R^2	0.035	0.036	0.036	0.037	0.035	0.036
F -statistic	248.80***	87.47***	86.58***	88.26***	84.85***	87.30***
Observations	6852	6852	6852	6845	6852	6852

Notes: The reference category for *NJA* is the Japanese applicant (Taro Yamamoto). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

implying that higher-income respondents perceive a stronger penalty. Model (6) distinguishes respondents by educational attainment (degree vs. no degree). Respondents with a degree perceive a larger disadvantage for non-native applicants.

Compared with results for Luxembourg by Lepinteur et al. (2025), our findings show both clear parallels and some differences across the heterogeneity dimensions examined. Most importantly, Models (3) and (4) align with their results in showing no meaningful heterogeneity by gender and stronger perceived discrimination among older respondents. However, Model (6) reveals a different education gradient: whereas Lepinteur et al. (2025) find stronger discrimination among less-educated participants, our results suggest that respondents with a degree perceive a larger disadvantage for non-native applicants.

To further investigate the education effect in Model (6), we estimate the specification on subsamples defined by participants’ nationality. When including participants from Asian countries with comparatively strong education systems (Japan, China, Taiwan, and South Korea), the estimated interaction effect remains qualitatively similar but becomes smaller in magnitude.

We further test whether restricting the sample to native Japanese or foreign-born respondents alters the effects in Models (2)–(6). The results remain quite stable across these restricted samples, and we do not find substantially different estimates when focusing on either group separately.

Overall, perceived discrimination varies systematically with age, income, and education, but not gender. Older, higher-income, and university-educated respondents perceive larger disadvantages for non-Japanese applicants, whereas the estimated effects are otherwise stable across respondent subgroups. This suggests that perceptions of differential treatment reflect a broader social understanding of housing market accessibility. In a regulatory environment in which nationality-based screening remains publicly visible and is not subject to comprehensive statutory prohibition, such perceptions may be reinforced through shared social and regulatory knowledge.

5.3 The Role of Foreign-Born Respondents’ Own Experience of Discrimination

Additional questions elicit foreign-born respondents’ self-reported experiences of discrimination ($N = 195$ valid), as detailed in subsection 4.3. Respondents are presented with four scenarios capturing how others behave towards them in different contexts. Responses are coded such that lower values correspond to more frequent experiences of unequal treatment. In addition to examining each dimension separately, we construct an individual-level index of experienced discriminatory behaviour by averaging responses across the four scenarios.

As shown in Figure 7 in the Appendix, only a small fraction of foreign-born respondents report never having experienced discriminatory behaviour. The modal response across all scenarios is “A few times a month” (see Table 5), indicating that recurring exposure to subtle forms of discrimination is common within the sample. These items capture everyday instances of unequal treatment adapted to the housing context and are expected to be closely related to respondents’ perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation.

To examine this relationship, we first estimate bivariate correlations between the stated probability of securing a viewing and the composite discrimination index. We find a positive yet modest correlation (Spearman’s $\rho = 0.125$, $H_0 : \rho = 0$ vs. $H_1 : \rho > 0$ rejects H_0 with p -value = 0.041), indicating that stated perceived viewing likelihoods capture a related—though not identical—construct to broader measures of perceived discrimination. Repeating this test separately for each discrimination dimension reveals that no individual component is, in isolation, statistically significantly correlated with the subjectively stated viewing probability. This

Table 5: Most Frequent Response for Each EDS Item

Question	Most frequent response	n	%
EDS1	A few times a month	68	34.2
EDS2	A few times a month	85	42.7
EDS3	A few times a month	107	53.8
EDS4	A few times a month	119	59.8

Notes: Entries report the modal response category for each EDS item. Percentages are the share of responses for that item selecting the modal category.

suggests that the observed association reflects the combined effect of multiple dimensions of perceived discrimination rather than any single category alone.

Table 6: Determinants of Respondents' Perceived Own Likelihood of Receiving a Viewing Invitation

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	41.045*** (8.864)	27.784** (11.265)	38.136*** (9.054)	37.077*** (12.427)	32.674*** (9.463)	23.362* (13.524)
EDS score	20.550*** (6.735)	18.542*** (6.775)	19.667*** (6.741)	20.950*** (6.806)	21.081*** (6.662)	18.440*** (6.853)
EDS score ²	-3.999*** (1.281)	-3.439*** (1.307)	-3.781*** (1.286)	-4.078*** (1.295)	-4.092*** (1.267)	-3.406** (1.328)
Language skills		1.441* (0.764)				1.166 (0.783)
Permanent visa			5.832 (3.953)			4.503 (4.035)
Length of stay				0.565 (1.238)		-0.396 (1.272)
Log income					4.897** (2.090)	4.382** (2.111)
Adj. R^2	0.039	0.051	0.045	0.035	0.061	0.065
F -statistic	4.91***	4.50***	4.02***	3.33**	5.18***	3.25***
Observations	195	195	195	195	195	195

Notes: The dependent variable is respondents' perceived own likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation. *EDS score* measures the frequency with which respondents report having experienced discriminatory behaviour. *Language skills* is defined as the sum of reading and speaking ability. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Next, we regress the stated probability of securing a viewing on the composite discrimination index and incrementally add further controls. We also test for a non-linear relationship between the two factors. Table 6 shows that respondents' perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation is systematically associated with their prior experiences of discrimination. Across all six specifications (1)–(6), the EDS score enters positively and is highly statistically significant, while its squared term is negative and statistically significant throughout, confirming a robust nonlinear relationship. This implies that respondents with more frequent prior discrimination experiences (i.e., lower EDS scores) report lower expected probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation, whereas those who report less frequent discrimination express more optimistic ex-

pectations. The negative coefficient on the squared term further suggests diminishing marginal effects: the positive association between more favourable past treatment and perceived viewing chances weakens at higher levels of the EDS index.

Furthermore, we examine whether integration into Japanese society is associated with individuals' perceived success in the housing application process. Integration is proxied by permanent residency status, length of stay in Japan, and self-reported Japanese language proficiency. Length of stay, included in specifications (4) and (6), is statistically insignificant in both models, suggesting that time spent in Japan does not meaningfully explain variation in perceived probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation. Japanese language proficiency, introduced in specifications (2) and (6), is positively associated with perceived success and weakly significant in specification (2); however, the effect becomes statistically insignificant in specification (6) once additional controls are included, indicating limited robustness. Permanent residency status, included in specifications (3) and (6), also remains positive but statistically insignificant throughout.

In contrast, economic resources appear to matter. Log income, included in specifications (5) and (6), enters positively and is statistically significant in both models, suggesting that higher-income respondents report more optimistic expectations regarding their rental prospects.

Overall, while the models explain only a limited share of the variation in perceived viewing probabilities (adjusted R^2 ranging from 0.035 to 0.065 across specifications (1)–(6)), they consistently indicate that prior experiences of discrimination are a key determinant of respondents' expectations. Income also plays a meaningful role, whereas conventional indicators of integration—such as language proficiency, visa status, and length of stay—show limited and non-robust associations. By contrast, perceptions of group-level success, namely the collective perceived success of foreign-born respondents in the Japanese housing market, appear to be more strongly associated with perceived individual outcomes. Taken together, these findings suggest that subjective expectations in the rental housing market are shaped less by individuals' own integration characteristics and more by broader perceptions of how foreign-born respondents are treated within Japanese society, with economic resources playing a secondary but still important role.

5.4 Group-Level Perceptions versus Individual Expectations

As motivated in subsection 4.3, we test whether individuals differentiate between anticipated group-level discrimination and their own expected treatment, following the personal-group discrimination discrepancy (Dion, 2001). Specifically, we examine whether respondents assign lower probabilities of securing a viewing to their ethnic group in general than to themselves.

To this end, we regress participants' self-perceived likelihood of securing a viewing on the probability they attribute to applicants of their own nationality. The analysis focuses on respondents for whom a corresponding nationality profile is available, namely Japanese, Vietnamese, Chinese, South Korean, and Indonesian applicants.

Under the hypothesis of optimistic self-assessment relative to the group, the coefficient on the matched nationality profile should be strictly smaller than one.

Table 7 reports the results across six specifications. Models (1), (3), and (5) estimate log-log specifications, while models (2), (4), and (6) present results in levels. Across all specifications (1)–(6), the coefficient on the matched nationality profile is positive, highly statistically significant, and consistently below one, ranging from 0.643 to 0.647 in the log-log models and from 0.722 to 0.739 in the linear models. Indeed, in all specifications, the coefficient on the matched nationality profile is significantly smaller than one ($p < 0.001$), providing strong support for

the hypothesis that respondents evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of their nationality group.²⁹

This pattern provides strong and robust support for the hypothesis: respondents systematically rate their own chances of receiving a viewing invitation more favourably than those of applicants from their own nationality group.

The magnitude of the coefficient further suggests that while group-level perceptions strongly shape individual expectations, they are not translated one-to-one. Instead, individuals exhibit a clear optimism bias, discounting the degree of discrimination faced by their broader group when assessing their own prospects.

This result is stable across specifications. Models (1) and (2), which include nationality fixed effects, yield nearly identical coefficients to models (3) and (4), where these fixed effects are omitted but individual controls are introduced. Adding socioeconomic controls—such as log income and education—in models (3) and (4), and jointly with nationality fixed effects in models (5) and (6), leaves the coefficient on the matched nationality profile virtually unchanged. This indicates that the observed gap between individual and group-level expectations is not driven by observable characteristics such as income or education.

Regarding the control variables, higher income is positively and significantly associated with more optimistic self-assessed viewing probabilities in models (3)–(6), while the effect of education is weaker and not consistently robust across specifications. Nationality fixed effects in models (1), (2), (5), and (6) reveal level differences across groups but do not affect the central relationship of interest.

Overall, the findings provide strong evidence of a systematic divergence between perceived group discrimination and individual expectations. While respondents clearly recognise discriminatory patterns affecting their nationality, they simultaneously maintain more favourable beliefs about their own chances. This pattern may reflect cognitive mechanisms frequently invoked in the PGDD literature, but it may also reflect behavioural adaptation to perceived market conditions and broader social awareness of nationality-based barriers.

5.5 Interpreting the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy

A striking finding of the present study is that foreign-born respondents evaluated their own prospects of securing a rental viewing more favourably than those of their broader nationality group PGDD. While PGDD has often been interpreted as reflecting *optimism bias* or *self-serving attribution* processes, Taylor et al. (1996) propose a broader framework in which personal and group-level evaluations are shaped by partly distinct mechanisms.

First, individuals may minimise or discount discrimination directed at themselves as a psychological coping strategy. Acknowledging pervasive personal discrimination may threaten perceptions of personal agency and control, creating incentives to interpret one’s own experiences more favourably than those of the broader group. Such processes may contribute to the relatively optimistic self-assessments observed among foreign-born respondents in our study.

However, psychological coping alone is unlikely to fully explain the present findings. The Tokyo housing market contains a visible sub-market explicitly targeting foreign residents, while public and private initiatives increasingly seek to facilitate housing access for non-Japanese tenants. Foreign residents may therefore adapt behaviourally by directing their housing search toward

²⁹We test $H_0 : \beta = 1$ against the one-sided alternative $H_1 : \beta < 1$, using $t = (\hat{\beta} - 1)/SE(\hat{\beta})$. The null is rejected in all specifications (1)–(6), with test statistics of $t = -14.86$ in (1), -10.73 in (2), -15.22 in (3), -11.73 in (4), -15.17 in (5), and -11.14 in (6) (all $p < 0.001$).

Table 7: Group Perceptions vs. Individual Expectations

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Log-log	Linear	Log-log	Linear	Log-log	Linear
Intercept	0.224 (0.401)	-6.537 (12.062)	1.236*** (0.102)	12.300*** (2.059)	-0.037 (0.400)	-15.042 (12.027)
Matched nationality profile	0.647*** (0.024)	0.739*** (0.024)	0.643*** (0.023)	0.722*** (0.024)	0.643*** (0.024)	0.732*** (0.024)
Vietnam	1.238*** (0.461)	22.346 (13.981)			1.321*** (0.456)	24.994* (13.810)
China	1.417*** (0.406)	32.978*** (12.286)			1.488*** (0.402)	34.893*** (12.144)
Japan	1.164*** (0.400)	23.199* (12.132)			1.259*** (0.396)	26.159** (11.992)
South Korea	1.233*** (0.419)	25.352** (12.677)			1.299*** (0.414)	27.324** (12.522)
Log income			0.097*** (0.026)	2.801*** (0.794)	0.102*** (0.026)	2.921*** (0.790)
Degree			0.082* (0.049)	3.820** (1.497)	0.063 (0.050)	3.085** (1.498)
Nationality FE	✓	✓			✓	✓
SE Controls			✓	✓	✓	✓
Adj. R^2	0.462	0.513	0.465	0.518	0.474	0.525
F -statistic	155.50***	190.20***	261.80***	322.50***	116.90***	143.10***
Observations	900	900	900	900	900	900

Notes: The dependent variable is respondents' self-perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation. In log-log models, the dependent variable and matched nationality profile are transformed as $\log(1 + x)$. The matched nationality profile is the perceived viewing likelihood for the applicant profile corresponding to the respondent's own nationality. The omitted nationality category is Indonesia. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

landlords, agencies, or platforms known to be more receptive to foreign applicants. Under such conditions, personal experiences need not mirror perceptions of opportunities available to the broader group. Respondents may therefore simultaneously recognise substantial barriers facing non-Japanese residents in general while believing that they themselves can successfully navigate those barriers through accumulated experience, local knowledge, language skills, or targeted search strategies.

Normatively, however, the emergence of specialised housing pathways for foreign residents may itself be a cause for concern. Even where such arrangements improve practical access to housing, they risk normalising a form of market segregation in which equal access is replaced by separate channels of accommodation for different groups. From a comparative perspective, this evokes familiar criticisms of 'separate but equal' arrangements, which have been regarded in anti-discrimination law as incompatible with genuine equality.

Second, Taylor et al. (1996) argue that perceptions of discrimination directed at the broader group may be shaped by awareness of collective disadvantage acquired through observation, public discourse, and exposure to discriminatory incidents affecting other group members. In this sense, group-level evaluations need not emerge solely from personal experience. Rather, they may reflect broader social representations concerning the treatment of a particular group within society.

The Tokyo context provides several mechanisms through which such collective perceptions may

emerge. As documented in section 3, publicly accessible rental advertisements continue to contain explicit exclusionary language, conditional acceptance criteria, and nationality-related screening signals. Although the prevalence of such practices within the market as a whole cannot be inferred directly from these observations, their visibility may nevertheless contribute to perceptions that non-Japanese residents face systematic barriers in accessing rental housing. Repeated exposure to exclusionary signals, media reporting on housing discrimination, and awareness of discriminatory experiences among other foreign residents may collectively reinforce what might be described as a group-level *auto-stereotype* – a broadly shared expectation that members of one’s group are likely to encounter disadvantage in the housing market.

Importantly, the present findings suggest that such perceptions are not confined to foreign-born respondents. Across respondent groups, non-Japanese applicants were consistently evaluated as having lower probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation than otherwise identical Japanese applicants. The existence of this expectation among native Japanese respondents is particularly noteworthy. Whereas traditional PGDD accounts focus primarily on discrepancies between personal and group-level evaluations among minority members themselves, our results indicate that perceptions of group disadvantage are socially shared across the wider population. In other words, the expectation of unequal treatment appears to function not merely as a minority belief but as a collectively recognised feature of the housing market.

Taken together, the findings are consistent with a dual-process interpretation of PGDD. Personal evaluations may be moderated by psychological coping mechanisms and behavioural adaptation, leading individuals to perceive their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader group. At the same time, group-level evaluations may be shaped by publicly visible signals of exclusion and widely shared beliefs concerning the treatment of non-Japanese residents. This combination provides a plausible explanation for why foreign-born respondents perceive substantial discrimination against non-Japanese applicants while simultaneously expressing comparatively optimistic assessments of their own chances within the same market.

6 Conclusions

This study examines perceived ethnic discrimination in Tokyo’s rental housing market using a survey experiment. Both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents expect applicants with non-Japanese names to face substantially lower chances of receiving a viewing invitation than an otherwise identical Japanese applicant. These findings suggest that unequal treatment in rental access is not only perceived by minority groups themselves, but is also widely recognised by the majority population.

The paper makes three main contributions. First, it provides new evidence on perceived discrimination in a non-Western housing market during a period of demographic, legal, and institutional change in Japan, where growing reliance on foreign labour coexists with weak explicit protections against discrimination in private rental markets. Second, by focusing on subjective expectations rather than realised outcomes, it complements the large correspondence-study literature and highlights how perceptions themselves may shape housing-search behaviour and market participation. Third, the paper contributes to the limited literature on the personal-group discrimination discrepancy (PGDD) in housing contexts by showing that respondents systematically assess their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group.

Several additional findings emerge from the analysis. Native Japanese respondents perceive larger penalties for non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents, although both groups rank applicants similarly overall. Perceived disadvantage also varies systematically

across ethnic categories, with Western-Japanese applicants viewed as substantially closer to native Japanese applicants than other non-Japanese groups. In addition, perceptions differ across respondents' socio-economic characteristics: older, higher-income, and university-educated respondents perceive larger disadvantages for non-native applicants, whereas gender differences are limited.

Among foreign-born respondents, prior experiences of everyday discrimination are strongly associated with more pessimistic expectations regarding rental access. By contrast, conventional indicators of integration—such as visa status and length of stay—show comparatively limited explanatory power. These findings suggest that subjective experiences and broader perceptions of social treatment may shape expectations in the housing market more strongly than formal indicators of integration alone.

The PGDD finding also provides insight into how perceptions of discrimination may be formed and maintained. Consistent with the framework proposed by Taylor et al. (1996), the discrepancy between personal and group-level evaluations suggests that perceptions of housing access operate simultaneously at individual and collective levels. Foreign-born respondents may evaluate their own prospects more favourably because they adapt their search behaviour, acquire local knowledge, or successfully access segments of the market that are more receptive to foreign tenants. At the same time, perceptions of disadvantage directed at the broader group may be reinforced through publicly visible exclusionary signals, media reporting, and awareness of discriminatory experiences affecting other foreign residents. Importantly, the expectation that non-Japanese applicants face lower chances of receiving a viewing invitation was shared not only by foreign-born respondents but also by native Japanese respondents. This suggests that perceptions of unequal access have become socially shared understandings of the housing market rather than merely reflections of individual experience.

Overall, the results highlight a gap between formal access to housing and perceived access to housing in contemporary Japan. This gap is particularly important in light of Japan's legal and institutional framework. Although nationality-based exclusion in housing has, in some cases, been recognised as unlawful through general civil-law principles, Japan lacks explicit statutory housing anti-discrimination provisions and an independent equality body with binding enforcement powers. The findings therefore suggest that perceived discrimination is not only a matter of individual expectations or isolated landlord behaviour, but also of socially shared beliefs regarding who is likely to gain access to housing and who is perceived as belonging within the market. More broadly, the results resonate with scholarship on East Asian migration regimes arguing that foreign labour is frequently incorporated through systems of conditional and temporary belonging rather than full social membership (Bell and Piper, 2005).

As Japan's foreign-born population continues to grow, reducing both perceived and actual barriers in rental markets may require more than case-by-case remedies. Greater transparency in tenant-screening processes, clearer legal standards for real-estate agents and landlords, and institutional mechanisms that signal equal access to housing as a binding norm may be necessary to make non-discriminatory rental access credible in practice. In this sense, housing anti-discrimination law may matter not only by deterring unlawful conduct, but also through its expressive function: by shaping whether exclusionary screening is perceived as socially and institutionally tolerated.

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Appendix

A Historical Development of Tokyo's Rental Housing Market

This appendix provides additional historical and institutional background on the development of Tokyo's rental housing market.

A.1 Spatial Order under Tokugawa Japan and the Development of Rental Housing

The feudal order of Tokugawa Japan (1603–1868) had a lasting influence on Edo's urban structure and, by extension, on the development of what is now Tokyo's rental housing market. Edo was organised around the political authority of the Tokugawa shogunate and the spatial hierarchy of samurai and daimyo households. Daimyo were themselves differentiated into hierarchical categories, including *shimpan*, *fudai*, and *tozama*, with politically trusted groups located closer to the centre of power.

This spatial and political hierarchy reflected broader insider–outsider distinctions within Tokugawa society. These distinctions were embedded in household-based forms of social organisation and dependency, in which tenants, servants, and retainers could be incorporated into quasi-familial structures, while those outside such networks were positioned as social outsiders. Historical accounts suggest that this distinction continued to shape modern perceptions of non-Japanese residents as socially separate outsiders.

The concentration of daimyo and samurai households in Edo also contributed to the development of rental arrangements. Samurai land was not freely alienable in the same way as commercially transferable urban land in cities such as Osaka. As a result, financially constrained samurai households increasingly rented out land rather than transferring ownership. This practice later spread beyond samurai districts and contributed to the historically high prevalence of rental housing in Tokyo.

Following the Meiji Restoration and the Land Tax Reform, land became increasingly commodified and subject to taxation. These institutional changes further incentivised landlords to generate income through leasing while retaining ownership. At the same time, landownership continued to carry symbolic and status-related significance, particularly in former samurai districts. These historical developments contributed to the long-standing importance of rental housing in Tokyo.

A.2 Wartime Tenant Protection and Long-Term Tenure Security

The introduction of the *Building Protection Act*, the *Land Lease Act*, and the *Building Lease Act* before and after WWI was driven by rapid land price inflation, which incentivised landlords to transfer land to third-party to remove tenants whose leasehold interests lacked proprietary protection under Japanese civil law.

However, the decisive transformation of Japanese tenant protection occurred during the transition toward a total-war economy, following the Second Sino-Japanese War beginning in 1937. Against the background of wartime militarism, the government sought to stabilise urban labour supply for armament production and the war economy. Under the National Mobilisation Law (1938), the government introduced the *Rent Control Order* in October 1939, shortly after the wartime rent control in the United Kingdom in September 1939 and Germany's nationwide rent freeze in 1936. The 1939 Order froze the rent *ex post* at the August 1938 level, which may be categorised as a first-generation rent control due to its rigidity under Arnott (1995)'s distinction between 'first-generation' and 'second-generation' rent control regimes, although Arnott's

analysis primarily concerns North American and European housing markets. Shortly before the Pearl Harbor attack, the 1941 amendments to the *Land Lease Act* and the *Building Lease Act* sought to give practical effect to wartime rent control by preventing landlords from circumventing rent restrictions through eviction threats and demands for illegal surcharges. The amendments maximised tenure security by introducing automatic renewal mechanisms and the 'just cause' requirement, severely restricting landlords' ability to refuse renewal or terminate leases.

Japan was therefore not an outlier but part of a broader international pattern: many countries introduced or strengthened rent-control and tenant-protection measures in response to war-related inflation, soaring rents, housing shortages, and still-limited general tenant protections (Kholodilin, 2024; Kholodilin et al., 2021). In Japan, however, wartime tenant-protection mechanisms did not remain merely temporary emergency measures. As the March 1945 firebombing significantly reduced Tokyo's housing stock, owing to the combination of densely built urban neighborhoods and highly flammable wooden housing, the wartime tenant-protection regimes survived the end of the war, as occurred in several European jurisdictions. The postwar *Act on Land and Building Lease* largely inherited the framework established through the wartime amendments, particularly the strong renewal protections and the 'just cause' requirement. This legal framework contributed to the widely recognised landlord perception that 'once leased out, never comes back.' This institutional structure has contributed to persistent risk-averse behaviour among landlords in the Japanese rental housing market.

A.3 Postwar and Post-Bubble Developments

The postwar rental housing system continued to be shaped by strong tenant protections and long-term rental reliance. Although the 2000 amendment introduced fixed-term building leases as an alternative to ordinary leases, the fixed-term system remained relatively uncommon for more than two decades. Ordinary leases, to which automatic renewal and the "just cause" requirement continue to apply, remained the dominant framework.

The prolonged decline in land prices following the burst of Japan's asset-price bubble in the early 1990s further reinforced the relative stability of rental tenancies. During this period, landlords had limited incentives to terminate existing leases for redevelopment or rent increases. At the same time, concerns over negative equity, mortgage availability, and the relatively short economic lifespan of many Japanese housing structures contributed to continued reliance on rental housing among younger and more mobile households.

In this institutional context, Tokyo's rental market differs from housing systems in which renting is primarily treated as a short transitional stage before homeownership. Instead, rental housing constitutes a central and often long-term tenure form. This makes access to rental housing particularly important for social and economic integration, especially for foreign-born residents whose housing opportunities are mediated through private landlords and real-estate agents.

B Survey Administration and Data Quality Procedures

The survey was administered online through *GMO Research*, one of the largest panel providers in Japan, in combination with the Qualtrics survey platform. GMO was selected due to its broad demographic coverage and ability to recruit foreign-born residents within the Greater Tokyo area, a population that is difficult to access through conventional survey methods.

Online panel data are increasingly used in behavioural and urban research due to their scalability, participant diversity, and compatibility with experimental survey designs (Porter et al., 2019; Asad et al., 2023; Bao and Saunders, 2023). Qualtrics was used for questionnaire imple-

mentation and survey logic, while GMO acted as the participant recruitment intermediary.

Several procedures were implemented to improve data quality. First, the survey incorporated minimum completion-time thresholds to identify low-effort responses. Second, response completeness checks and consistency checks were applied throughout the questionnaire. Third, device metadata and geolocation validation were used to confirm respondents' location within the Greater Tokyo area. Duplicate participation was prevented through unique user identifiers.

The survey was initially developed in English before being translated into Japanese and additional foreign languages commonly used by foreign residents in Japan. Translations were reviewed by native speakers to ensure linguistic consistency and minimise interpretation bias.

A pilot phase and pre-programming process were conducted prior to fieldwork to verify survey logic, randomisation procedures, and respondent flow. Data collection took place in April 2025.

C Construction and Validation of Applicant Names

C.1 Selection of Applicant Profiles

Applicant profiles were constructed using *Japanese Immigration Agency* (2024) data to reflect the composition of the 30.7% increase in migrants between 2018 and 2025. The selected profiles correspond to the principal nationality and visa groups represented in Tokyo's foreign resident population. In addition to foreign-born applicant groups, two benchmark profiles were included: a native Japanese applicant and a Western-Japanese applicant (i.e., a foreign-born individual of partial Japanese descent). The latter group was included because prior research suggests that co-ethnicity and perceived cultural proximity may shape evaluations of migrants in Japan (Shipper, 2016).

All applicant characteristics other than names were held constant across profiles in order to isolate perceptions associated with ethnic signals conveyed through names. Applicant identities were standardised as male to reflect prevailing market norms and minimise gender-related variation. This approach is supported by evidence indicating that males may face greater discrimination in rental markets, thereby reducing the need for gender-based stratification (Ahmed and Hammarstedt, 2008; Huang and Bao, 2026). Gender-ambiguous names were avoided to ensure clarity.

C.2 Name Validation Procedure

To ensure that applicant names were recognisable and consistently associated with the intended ethnic categories, a bilingual pre-test was conducted using a sample of 100 respondents recruited through *Prolific*, supplemented by targeted recruitment of Japanese participants.

Respondents were asked to identify the likely ethnic background associated with each name. Names were retained only if they achieved a recognition accuracy threshold of at least 70%, consistent with conventions in correspondence-study research (e.g., Ahmed and Hammarstedt, 2008). Names failing to meet this threshold were excluded from the final survey instrument.

Mean recognisability was higher in English-language responses (94%) than in Japanese-language responses (83%), reflecting linguistic constraints associated with transliteration into Japanese script. While ANOVA results showed no statistically significant differences across names, the model explained more than 60% of the variation in recognition outcomes, indicating meaningful differentiation between applicant categories.

The name validation exercise additionally served as a pilot test for the broader experimental

design by assessing whether ethnic signals embedded in names remained sufficiently salient once presented in Japanese script.

C.3 Script Standardisation and Linguistic Design

A key methodological consideration was whether names would remain ethnically distinguishable once translated into Japanese script. To preserve ethnic salience while maintaining comparability across profiles, non-Japanese names were standardised using Katakana characters, which are conventionally used in Japanese for foreign names and loan words. Distinctly Japanese names were presented in Kanji characters. For Western–Japanese profiles, first names were rendered in Katakana and surnames in Kanji to preserve cultural plausibility and reflect mixed ethnic identity.

This approach standardised the presentation of applicant names while enhancing the perceptual salience of ethnic categories that were not Japanese. Prior studies emphasise that Katakana script itself conveys social and ethnic meaning in Japanese contexts (Hanai, 2016). However, loan words written in Katakana do not automatically trigger a specific ethnic association unless supported by cultural familiarity or media exposure (Tamaoka and Miyaoka, 2003). Consequently, respondents’ perceptions of names are shaped not only by phonetic structure but also by broader social experience, making Katakana particularly appropriate for studying implicit bias and perceived foreignness.

Particular care was also taken to avoid pronunciation or character ambiguities across East Asian languages. For example, the Chinese surname character 張, commonly pronounced “Zhang” in Mandarin, is pronounced “Chō” in Japanese contexts. To avoid such ambiguities, native Chinese characters were not used directly in the applicant profiles. Instead, names were transliterated into Katakana to ensure that respondents interpreted ethnic signals consistently across profiles.

The final applicant profiles and their corresponding renderings in native script and Katakana are presented in Table 1.

C.4 Translation Procedures

The survey was originally developed in English and translated into Japanese using machine translation, followed by verification by four native speakers. Additional language versions were subsequently developed for Indonesian, Simplified Chinese, English, Hindi, Korean, Burmese, Nepali, Portuguese, and Vietnamese, reflecting the language categories used in the Ministry of Justice Basic Foreign Residents’ Survey and covering the largest foreign resident groups in Japan.

The multilingual implementation was designed to maximise accessibility among foreign-born residents while minimising interpretation bias across respondent groups. Japanese was set as the default language option. Active switching to an alternative language version was interpreted as an indicator of lower cultural assimilation and incorporated into the broader analysis of integration-related characteristics.

D Supplemental Questions for Non-Native Japanese Speakers

D.1 Japanese Language Ability

Speaking Ability

Question: How well can you carry a conversation in Japanese?

1. I can carry on a conversation appropriately with anyone, in any situation, on any subject.
2. I can converse fluently and naturally.
3. I can converse as needed in everyday life.
4. I can exchange basic information about family matters.
5. I can use frequently-used greetings and everyday phrases.
6. I cannot carry on a conversation at all.

Reading Ability

Question: How well can you read Japanese?

1. I can read any written material with ease.
2. I can read newspaper articles that are written from certain perspectives.
3. I can read emails that are written using everyday words and phrases.
4. I can read short and easy writings about familiar matters.
5. I can read familiar names and words used in signs and posters.
6. I cannot read well at all.

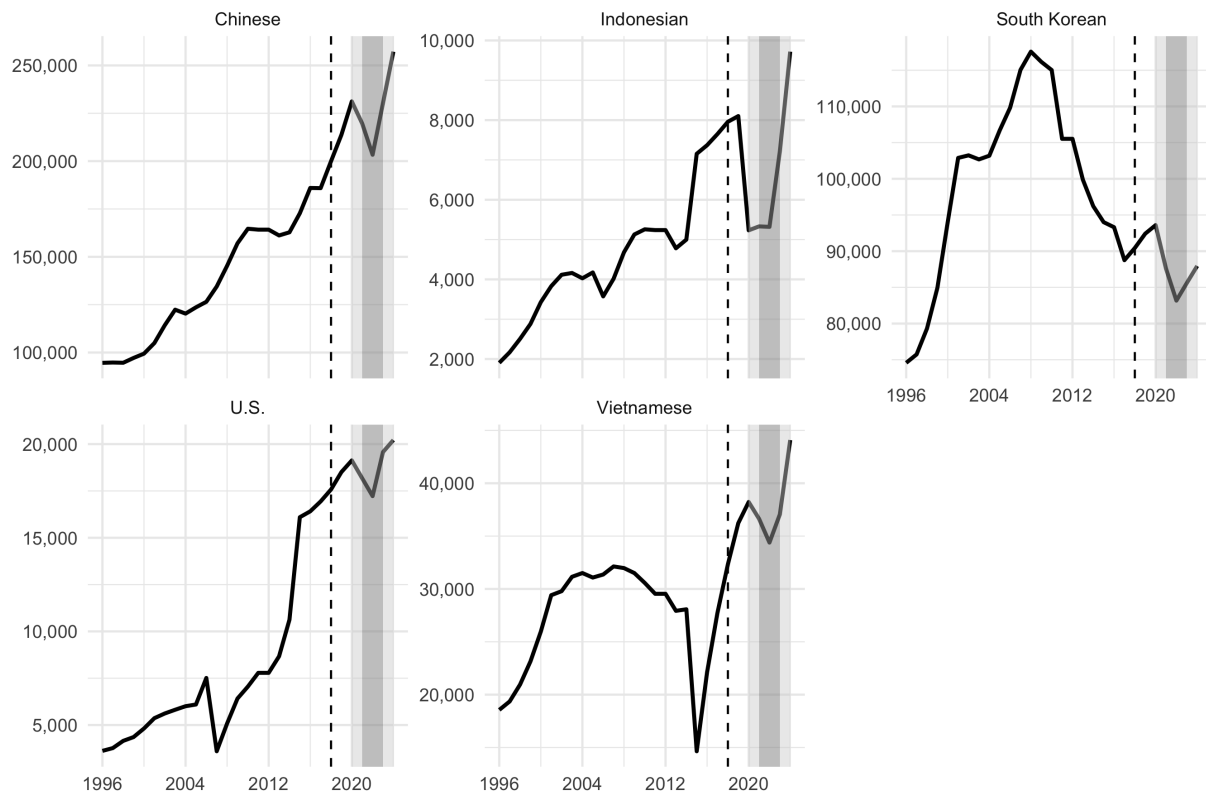
D.2 Everyday Discrimination Scale (EDS)

Question: In your day-to-day life, how often do any of the following things happen to you?

a) Situations

1. You are treated with less courtesy than other people.
2. You receive poorer service than other people at restaurants or stores.
3. People act as if they are afraid of you.
4. People act as if they think that you are dishonest.

Figure 6: Major Nationality Groups among Foreign Residents in Tokyo



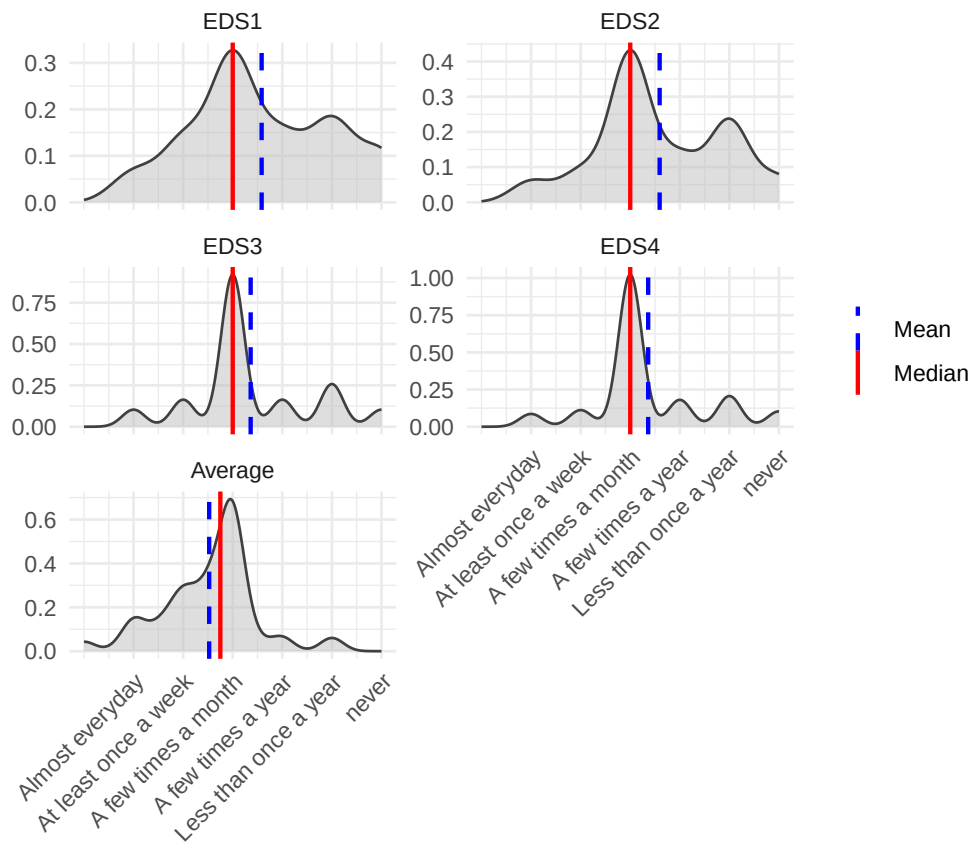
Notes: The dashed vertical line marks the 2018 Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act reform. Shaded areas indicate the COVID-19 period. The darker shaded region corresponds to years fully affected by pandemic-related restrictions, while lighter shaded regions correspond to partially affected years. Data are from the *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook*.

b) Response Scale

- Almost every day
- At least once a week
- A few times a month
- A few times a year
- Less than once a year
- Never

E Additional Figures and Tables

Figure 7: EDS responses



Notes: The Figure shows densities of each EDS question as well as the density of the composite index achieved as an average across responses.

Table 8: Top Five Visa Groups in Japan

Visa Status	Representative Nationality	Population	Characteristics
Highly Skilled Professional	China (Europe second)	17,912	High skill, high income, high language proficiency
Specified Skilled Worker	Indonesia	44,305	Lower skill, lower income, low language proficiency
Technical Training Intern	Vietnam	44,305	Lower skill, lower income
Permanent Resident	China	336,086	Higher skill, high language proficiency
Special Permanent Resident	South Korea	250,881	Cultural ties, high integration

Note: Data obtained from the Japanese Immigration Agency (2024).

Table 9: Summary Statistics

Variable	Mean / Share (%)	P25	Median	P75	SD
<i>All respondents</i>					
Age	48.10	39.00	50.00	57.00	12.60
Income (brackets)	6.05	2.00	6.00	9.00	3.99
Japanese	80.50%				
Female	40.60%				
Owner-occupier	52.80%				
Degree	58.00%				
Full-time employed	47.20%				
<i>Non-Japanese residents</i>					
Age	45.10	36.00	45.00	53.00	13.40
Income (brackets)	6.48	3.00	7.00	10.00	4.01
Female	51.20%				
Owner-occupier	52.70%				
Degree	70.90%				
Full-time employed	52.70%				
Length of stay	5.27	5.00	5.00	7.00	1.55
Speaking proficiency	4.94	4.00	5.00	6.00	1.36
Reading proficiency	4.94	4.00	6.00	6.00	1.43
Permanent visa	61.10%				

Notes: The Table reports summary statistics on all variables used. Numbers are computed for the full sample as well as the subsample of non-native participants.

Table 10: Highest- and Lowest-Ranked Non-Japanese Applicants by Respondent Nationality

Respondent nationality	Highest-ranked applicant	Lowest-ranked applicant
Japan	Western Japanese	Indonesia
China	Western Japanese	Chinese
Taiwan	Western Japanese	Vietnamese
South Korea	Western Japanese	Vietnamese
Vietnam	Western Japanese	South Korean

Notes: This Table complements the aggregate rankings shown in Figure 5 by reporting the highest- and lowest-ranked non-Japanese applicants within selected respondent-nationality groups. Nationality-specific rankings for smaller respondent groups should be interpreted descriptively due to limited sample sizes.